

Initial Post

by [Abdulla Husain Salem Hadna Almessabi](#) - Thursday, 4 December 2025, 11:50 AM

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The ethical issue raised in the case of Abi is beyond data integrity, and it goes to the very root of professional responsibility in data science and statistical analysis. Although data fabrication is undoubtedly unethical, analyzing valid data selectively to serve a predetermined purpose is referred to as p-hacking or hypothesis fishing (Andrade, 2021). This is also called confirmation bias. It negates the scientific method and the responsibility of a researcher to find the objective truth (Erasmus, 2025).

Abi is required to provide a balanced analysis. This is facilitated by the code of ethics of professional major bodies. Indicatively, the Association of Computing Machinery (ACM) Code of Ethics declares that computing professionals must be honest and trustworthy as well as pursue high quality in the processes and products of the professional work (ACM, 2018). Publication of positive correlations only, and derailing of detrimental results, contravenes these principles. Morally, the major responsibility of Abi lies in the integrity of the science and social good, rather than in the commercial interests of the manufacturer. In legal terms, in some jurisdictions such as the UK or the EU, deliberately making misleading claims on nutritional value may result in a breach of consumer laws (such as Consumer Protection from Unfair Trading Regulations 2008) and food labelling law, and may result in liability against both the manufacturer and, in the event of conspiracy, also the researcher.

The issue of accountability for the usage of results by other people is not simple (Resnik and Hosseini, 2025). Although Abi is not able to regulate all of the downstream actions, he has a serious professional obligation to deliver results in a manner that causes as little misinterpretation as possible. The professionals should take into account the potential effects of their actions, as contended by Gotterbarn et al. (2018). When Abi suspects that the manufacturer is only going to publish the positive analysis, his ethical duty increases. The following actions can be taken:

1. Escalation in the institute: Submitting both reports to the ethics or legal review board in his own institute so that they can provide guidance and institutional backing.
2. Conditional reporting: Provision of the full report with express written highlights on the methodological validity and the importance of the negative findings to public health.
3. Whistleblowing: In a final act, if the manufacturer is aware of derogatory results, it is professionally required in the public interest to report the matter to a competent regulatory body (e.g., the Food Standards Agency in the UK).

Abi, personally, and his institute, professionally, have their credibility at stake. Socially and culturally, the consequence of withholding information on a potentially dangerous foodstuff damages the confidence of the people in science and its direct health implications (Baba and Esfandiari, 2023). The line of least harm, which consists in giving both analyses as well as in leaving the selection of the manufacturer to himself, is a violation of his professional responsibility. His position is not that of an unbiased technician of evidence but that of a prudent custodian of evidence.

References

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